Certain other investments offer higher income earning prospects but they are totally unsafe as in the case of gambling, horse race, lottery, speculation and so on and so forth. Therefore an individual investor has to park the surplus funds judiciously so as to balance the liquidity, safety and profitability.

Following are some of the investment options available to individual investor

1. Public Provident Fund (PPF)

It is the safest long-term investment option for the investors in India. It is totally tax-free. PPF account can be opened in bank or post office. The money deposited cannot be withdrawn before 15 years and an investor can earn compound interest from this account. However the investor can extend the time frame for the next five years if the investor does not opt to withdraw the amount matured for payment at maturity date. PPF investor can take loan against PPF account when he/she experiences financial difficulties.

2. Mutual Funds

An individual investor who wants to invest in equities and bond with a balance of risk and return generally can invest in mutual funds. Nowadays people invest in stock markets through a mutual fund. Systematic investment plan is one of the best investment options in India.

3. Direct Equity or Share Purchase

An individual can opt for investment in shares. But he has to analyse the market price of various shares traded in stock exchange, reputation of the company, consistency in the payment of dividend, the nature of the project undertaken by the company, growth prospects of industry in which a company is operating, before investing in shares. If the investment is made for a long time, it may yield good return. However there is equally risky to invest in shares as there is no guaranteed return therein.

4. Real Estate Investment

Real estate is one of the fastest growing sectors in India. Buying a flat or plot is supposed to be the best decision amongst the investment options. The value of the real asset may increase substantially depending upon the area of location and other support facilities available therein. However an investor in real estate has to be cautious and circumspect in verifying the genuineness of the title deeds before investing in real estate assets and also the reputation of seller of real assets.

5. Investing in Metals

Investment in metals like gold, silver and platinum is one of the oldest and evergreen investment products. The values of the metals rise slowly and steadily in line with the dynamic market conditions. But investors can liquidate the metals immediately in the market without any loss. Besides an investor can opt for investment format, like gold deposit scheme, gold ETF (exchange-traded fund), Gold Bar, Gold mutual fund etc., to get benefit in the short period of time.

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